

COUNTRY



VANDAN DEODHAR

"Land-use changes, lack of waste disposal system, coastal erosion and tourism are exerting pressure on the marine and coastal environment".

The state today is a big heap of garbage owing to the total collapse of waste management system which has failed to keep pace with unprecedented urbanisation. No city including the laidback capital Thiruvananthapuram, cosmopolitan Kochi or even villages have any scientific system for waste disposal, garbage dumping yards or effective recycling systems. According to PCB, one million cubic metres of sewage is generated in the state's coastal areas, of which 30,000 cubic metres reach the surface of water bodies. The backwaters in Kochi alone receive 60 tonne of sewage from the city.

Everything that could go wrong has gone wrong. Kerala's idyllic beaches have been ravaged by unauthorised constructions, its heavenly hills devastated by deforestation and encroachment driven by lucrative tourism potential. Down the beaches, waves lash at the foot of the unauthorised hotels and restaurants which have gobbled up the sea front. Most of them release their waste directly on the beach providing a feast for stray dogs which stalk the shores round-the-clock, terrifying tourists.

Two years ago, things were so bad in the state capital that a group of foreign tourists took the initiative of collecting garbage. The state Government then woke up and opted for an incinerator at Kovalam which forced the international environmentalist group, Greenpeace and Thanal, an NGO, to oppose the plans saying it would only lead to lethal consequences. In 2003, the two groups initiated a Zero Waste

DRIVEN BY TOURISM, KERALA'S IDYLIC BEACHES HAVE BEEN RAVAGED BY UNAUTHORISED CONSTRUCTIONS WHICH HAVE GOBBLED UP THE ENTIRE SEA FRONT

waterfront. "It is certainly God's own country. But man is fast turning it into the devil's backyard," says Gagne.

A deterioration has set in and at its current rate, the state's long-term sustainability as a paradise on earth, is under threat. The government itself has belatedly admitted that the major tourist destinations suffer from a host

of serious problems: piling of waste and garbage, water and air pollution, loss of biodiversity, lack of land-use and infrastructure planning, encroachment, unauthorised constructions and drinking water shortage among others. The worst affected is the state's spectacular coastline. A report of the state Pollution Control Board (PCB) says,

Kovalam project to clean up the beach and recycle the waste and make marketable goods from biodegradable items (*see box*). The zero waste project showed great promise initially with hundreds of volunteers from Greenpeace and Thanal being involved in waste collection and recycling. Their efforts hit headlines when they fished